> “WHEN BATTLE IS JOINED, NO NOBLE KNIGHT THINKS OF ANYTHING OTHER THAN BREAKING HEADS AND ARMS.”

BERTRAN DE BORN, FRENCH BARON AND TROUBADOUR (C.1140–1215)

minimum knightly combat. Nonetheless, heavily armoured, mounted knights were a formidable force whenever battle was joined in open field. At battles such as Bouvines in 1214 and Poitiers in 1356, knights formed up in their full splendour carried out classic charges and fought one another in savage mêlées mounted and on foot.

Well-made armour offered excellent protection and gave a knight full mobility to wield his lance, sword, or axe, in the saddle or out of it. The shock of close-quarters combat was, of course, intense and put a premium upon physical strength and endurance, especially if hot weather made the weight of the armour hard to bear. But fortified by their code of personal honour and duty, knights rarely flinched once combat was joined. Their chief weakness lay in the intemperate aggression and quarrelsomeness of hot-headed individuals bent upon glory. Chronicles of medieval warfare tell time and again of groups of knights unwisely breaking ranks to charge a superior enemy in a self-conscious show of competitive bravery, often in defiance of a battle plan agreed in advance. The knights' discipline rarely matched their valour.

Tournament armour
During the 16th century, specialist armour for use in tournaments became common. This ornate German suit features heavier protection along the more vulnerable left arm and shoulder, while ventilation holes are kept to the right-hand side of the visor.

LIVING ON

Even in the 14th century, the battlefield dominance of knights was challenged by lightly armoured foot soldiers at Courtrai and Bannockburn and by archers at Crécy. From the second half of the 15th century, gunpowder weapons were increasingly effective, as were disciplined infantry armed with pikes. But armoured cavalry was not driven from the battlefield by arrows, cannon or arquebuses. In something close to its medieval form it remained an important element in battles into the late 16th century. By then, however, the social and cultural basis of knighthood had declined with an increase in central state power and the inexorable rise of professional soldiering.

European swords
Early medieval swords were broad and heavy, used to hack through mail. As plate armour improved, swords grew longer and more sharply pointed for thrusting.

